Goin' Fishin'

By Chris Crutcher

There is a case to be made that from the time of birth our lives are made up of a series of losses and that our grace can be measured by how we face those losses and how we replace what is lost.

Lionel Serbousek lost his parents in a boating accident when he was fourteen years old. Though he continues to explore his passions, athletics and art-with fervor, he remains haunted by his memories of that day on the lake and "what could have been. . . ."

Like most of us, when his pain is the greatest, he covers it with anger, anger approaching rage. That rage has the power to consume.

INTRODUCTION

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My name is Lionel Serbousek. I'm a high school senior, an artist and a swimmer, and I'm also an orphan. I can tell no story about my life without telling this one first because it colors everything I do; everything I think.

I woke up on a bright Sunday morning almost 3 years ago to go fishing over in Lake Coeburn with my family, and everything was about as normal as it could be. At the beginning of that day things couldn't have been better, but by sundown I felt as alone as if I'd been hatched from an egg by the sun.

I think if human beings had even the slightest capacity to foretell the future, we'd be a completely different animal. In the moment that I helplessly watched my family's death unfold before me, I wished I'd lived differently, done my chores on time, told no lies, eaten my vegetables, thanked my parents for giving me a room of my own, told them I loved them, been a better big brother for Kyle.

The person who killed my family was my best friend. His name is Neal Anderson. I still get a card

every Christmas from his family, but I have avoided him like AIDS since the day of the accident.

Neal wasn't supposed to be driving his parents' boat that day.

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My father was a head shaker. He was one of those adults who believe that if you take time to tell your children things, they'll grow up believing them and act accordingly. Anytime that failed to happen, Dad would simply shake his head slowly. With me, Dad shook his head a lot.

If I'd known Dad was going to die, I'd have made a special effort to decrease the number of times a day he felt compelled to shake his head. But I thought I had more time. I thought I had all of time.

Fishing was a metaphor for life with my father. It required patience, knowledge, and skill. It wasn't frivolous, and on a good day you were rewarded immediately for doing it right, though certainly there were no guarantees. You could kid around with him about some things, but fishing wasn't one of them.

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That day we were dead still in the middle of the lake in early afternoon, fishing deeper water, when Neal and his buddies, at least two six-packs into the afternoon, decided to take a quick spin in his dad's Sun Runner. Nobody in our boat but me even saw them coming. I hollered; but Mom and Kyle were hauling in a fish, and Dad was shouting advice. They didn't even look up.

And I jumped. I jumped.

I've watched it over and over, always knowing if I'd stayed a little longer or yelled a little louder, I could have saved them.

Neal's boat cut ours in half. None of my family even bobbed to the surface. Kyle's shirt floated near the wreckage, and I dived as deep as I could, only to be surrounded by blackness. I didn't know it was Neal at the time, but I got hold of him and did my very best to drown him. I held him under with both hands on his throat, and it took all the other two had, plus help from a guy who saw it all from a passing boat, to pull me off.

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Swimming saved me. I took out my pain on the water. The louder the whine of the approaching Sun Runner echoed in my head, the clearer the sight of splintering fiberglass and flying bodies, the harder I swam. And slowly but surely the searing edge began to dull. I don't know if time heals all wounds, but I know it at least slows the spiritual bleeding.

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Elaine -- she was there for me always after the accident. She sensed when my loneliness was ready to smother me and would show up with food or friends or just her wonderful self. I never loved her, not like a girlfriend; but I cried with her, and I told her everything. Elaine Ferral knows my soul, and more than anyone, she walked with me through the land-mined terrain of my grief.

I really thought I had it all in perspective, but then, about a week ago, Neal Anderson showed up at my door. I haven't seen him since the day he killed my family. And that's a good thing, because when things are

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at their worst, and I want someone to blame, Neal's my man.

I stared at him through my open door. "What do you want?"

"Can I come in?"

I barely recognized him, wouldn't have if I hadn't heard his voice. His dishwater brown hair was stringy and unkempt, hanging to his shoulders; his clothes were dirty and threadbare. I considered a moment and said, "No." I was instantly aware of my rage.

"Come on, man. I need to talk to you."

"Anderson, if I let you come in my house, I'll probably hurt you. In fact, I might anyway. You must be out of your mind. What the hell are you doing here?"

"Trying to give myself a chance."

"A chance to what?"

"To make it right."

"Anderson, turn around. Walk down those stairs. If you see me on the street, at a dance, or in a pizza place, or even at a gas station, stop what you're doing and run. I'll let you know if it's ever different."

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He started down the rickety stairs, then turned back about halfway down. I noticed how thin he looked, how raggedy. All his athleticism, that confident gait he had was gone. He said, "I'm not leaving because I'm afraid you'll hurt me. Nothin' you could do to me would matter. I'm just leavin' because you want me to."

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It was later that night when I realized how vicious I'd been. And it felt good. That night I realized it's my rage that's kept me alive over these three years, not friendships. Make no mistake about it; if I had been left alone in the water with Neal that day, I would have drowned him. And I have never trusted for a moment since what I might do if I ran into him. Now he was feeling some of what I've felt over the past three years, and for all I cared, he could waste away to nothing.

Shortly afterward, my phone rang. "Hello. Make it fast."

"Lionel, this is Vicki Anderson."

Neal's mom.

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"Listen, Lion, I need to ask you a favor. A big favor. I'm calling about Neal. I know he came and saw you today."

"Yeah."

"Lionel, he's dying."

"Like my parents. My brother."

"Slower. Lion, I've never known what to say. I'm so embarrassed we haven't contacted you. I pray for you every night of my life. Neal's father has set up a trust for you . . ."

"Mrs. Anderson, money isn't going to bring my family back."

"If money could have brought your family back, we'd have already done that. It's just all we have."

"So what about Neal?"

"He needs you to forgive him."

"Won't happen. He killed my family."

"Lionel, he hasn't lived with us for more than six months. He's on the street. I think he's using drugs. I can't talk to him. He's dying, Lionel. Please, if not for him, then for me. For his father."

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Until that moment I hadn't the slightest inkling of the true power of my hate. The sorrow that rose in my chest for Mrs. Anderson was crushed by it. I said, "Mrs. Anderson, I'm sorry. But do you know what it's been like inside me for the last three years? Do you know how many times I've watched my parents and my little brother get cut in two? Do you know how much I've missed them? Mrs. Anderson, if I thought I could spend fifteen minutes with my little brother starting at the moment of my death, I'd be gone tonight."

"I'm sorry, Lionel. I'm sorry I bothered you."

I snatched my Speedo and a towel out of the bathroom and headed for the pool at Frost. I started with twenty-five-yard butterfly sprints, giving myself fifteen seconds between. I have no idea how many I swam, but my chest and triceps were molten steel when I pushed off and saw a body knife into the water beside me. I finished the lap and looked up to see Elaine.

"Go ahead and leave, I'm okay. I want to be alone."

"Tough shit."

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"Elaine, get out of here. I don't want to talk to anyone:'

"What're you gonna do, Lion? Beat me up? Like you did Neal Anderson. Or his mom."

"Hey, don't start. We go back a long way, but-"

"It's not a question of how far we go back. It's a question of if we'll go forward. You treated Neal Anderson like shit today."

"Neal Anderson is shit."

"It's for sure no one could tell you anything. What would your dad say? I knew your dad, Lion, and he'd call game on this cheap bullshit in a second. And your mom-"

"You leave my mom and dad out of this! I'm warning you, Elaine."

"Wanna hit me, Lion? Go ahead. That do it for you? Maybe that's what you need. Start right here with me, Lion. Go ahead."

My fist clenched, and my upper lip vibrated like a jackhammer, and she punched me in the stomach so hard the wind blasted out of me like a released party balloon.

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"You double up your fist at me you better be ready to I use it. You make me sick, Lionel Serbousek. When your family got killed, your friends gathered around you like angels. We spent the last three years making sure nothing touched you, treating you like some kind of boy in a bubble or something."

"You can cancel your friendship out anytime. What the hell is the matter with you, Elaine? Neal Anderson killed my family! If I ever quit hating him, I - I-I'll die right with them."

I dropped to the bleachers like a rock, dazed at what I had just heard myself say.

"Lion, remember the night you and Walker and Jeff and I drank all those beers and you took us out on the ice up at the lake? None of us knew the ice would hold-and it was four miles over icy two-lane roads to get there. You could have killed us. Easy. You were drunk out of your mind. What if you'd killed us, Lion, and you'd lived?"

"Yeah, well, I didn't. . . ."

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"No, but you could have. What you did was more stupid than what Neal did. Only thing is, the universe caught him and it didn't catch you. That's the only difference. . . . . Think about it! Think about it, Lion! . . . . "You only get so long to be an idiot, Lion. Just so long to get decent again. Your time's about up."

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It was my third night searching for Neal. His gaunt face had haunted me since Elaine stalked away from me; Mrs. Anderson's pain over the phone had become real. And the thought of losing Elaine lay in my stomach like a sharp rock.

I searched more than an hour and was finally ready to leave and try again tomorrow nightwhen I saw a dim light between the slats of the wooden bridge.

"Neal?"

He looked up dreamily, eyes glazed. His mom was right about the drugs.

"Lion? I killed your mom and dad, man. And your little brother."

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"Yeah. Look, Neal, I'm not over this yet, but we need to talk. Pack your stuff. Maybe you and me oughta go fishin'."

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